

CHAPTER SEVEN

Lesson Six: Work to Learn -Don't Work for Money

In 1995, I granted an interview with a newspaper in Singapore. The young female reporter was on time, and the interview got under way immediately. We sat in the lobby of a luxurious hotel, sipping coffee and discussing the purpose of my visit to Singapore. I was to share the platform with Zig Ziglar. He was speaking on motivation, and I was speaking on “The Secrets of the Rich.”

“Someday, I would like to be a best-selling author like you,” she said. I had seen some of the articles she had written for the paper, and I was impressed. She had a tough, clear style of writing. Her articles held a reader's interest.

“You have a great style,” I said in reply. “What holds you back from achieving your dream?”

“My work does not seem to go anywhere,” she said quietly. “Everyone says that my novels are excellent, but nothing happens. So I keep my job with the paper. At least it pays the bills. Do you have any suggestions?”

“Yes, I do,” I said brightly. “A friend of mine here in Singapore runs a school that trains people to sell. He runs sales-training courses for many of the top corporations here in Singapore, and I think attending one of his courses would greatly enhance your career.”

She stiffened. “Are you saying I should go to school to learn to sell?”

I nodded.

“You aren't serious, are you?”

Again, I nodded. “What is wrong with that?” I was now backpeddling. She was offended by something, and now I was wishing I had not said anything. In my attempt to be helpful, I found myself defending my suggestion.

“I have a master's degree in English Literature. Why would I go to school to learn to be a salesperson? I am a professional. I went to school to be trained in a profession so I would not have to be a salesperson. I hate salespeople. All they want is money. So tell me why I should study sales?” She was now packing her briefcase forcibly. The interview was over.

On the coffee table sat a copy of an earlier best-selling book I wrote. I picked it up as well as the notes she had jotted down on her legal pad. “Do you see this?” I said pointing to her notes.

She looked down at her notes. “What,” she said, confused.